

HS 312 – Introduction to Science and Technology Studies

Lecture 11
Mahendra Shahare

Against Method

- Paul Feyerabend – Austrian Philosopher @ University of Bristol, UC Berkeley; Book *Against Method* (1975)
- He questions and rejects on the grounds of history and logic, the belief @ existence of scientific method that distinguishes science from other cognitive activities
- Against ‘law and order’ Philosophy of Science – certain unchanging norms which determine scientific practice
- Give me any norm, I will show it is violated, not by oversight but consciously
- History of science goes against the idea of scientific method, since every possible norm has been violated

Against Method

- Two conditions that ought to be met by any theory – **consistency condition, correspondence condition**
- The new proposed theory must be **consistent** with the already well established theories
- The new proposed theory must **correspond** to the well established facts
- Feyerabend – both conditions are illegitimate as they hinder progress of science
- Overlooks the fact that the established theories may be faulty
- Since all observations are theory-laden, correspondence condition too cannot be sustained, as new theory might fail to correspond to facts
- Correspondence condition is primary as consistency condition can be reduced to it

Against Method

- Feyerabend – we must attempt to develop new theories that go **counter to so-called known facts**
- **Scientific pluralism** rejects fundamental doctrine that “all facts must belong to one grand scheme”
- Not call for abandoning empiricism but proposal that we must not insist that theories must produce data at the inception
- Galileo, Copernican theory and Ptolemaic theory – telescope
- Feyerabend maintains that relationship between successive theories is **incommensurable**

Against Method

- Methodological monism – Only one method for science irrespective of its subject matter
- Feyerabend – repudiates the idea of method in natural sciences, and roots for **methodological pluralism**
- **Post-paradigmatic** stage marked by plurality
- A line of demarcation between science and non-science – not absolute and logical but relative and historical
- Social science also works with some conception of method

Group Presentation

3	210010007	Akash Banger	Chapter 1		13	22B0919 Nitesh Singh
	22B1852	Akepogu Bhagya Raju	Edible knowledge: the chemical transfer of memory	5-Feb	22B0974	Nitin Singh Patel
	22B0684	Ankit			22B2155	Nitya Tiwari
	22B1026	Anumandla Vasavi Priya			22B1008	Nuthakki Rithik

Sources

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- NPTEL. Views of Paul Feyerabend.
- Harry Collins and Trevor Pinch (1998). Edible Knowledge: the chemical transfer of memory. Chapter 1, in *The Golem: what you should know about science*; second edition: Cambridge University Press, Cambridge UK.

Thank you